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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): Quarrels

This is the way to live. As in any society, many fall short of the ideal. Some women have tongues that wag constantly and violently, and their husbands spend their lives in continual turmoil; some men are notorious as wife-beaters and troublemakers. But the majority of Tonga couples seem to lead placid lives with a good deal of mutual tolerance, respect and affection. When a man says of his wife, 'She always understands what I say', he is giving her the highest praise that he has. A woman is more likely to say, 'There have never been harsh words between us.'

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Maintaining such harmony is not easy. A marriage has to contend with the fact that both husband and wife are members of matrilineal groups whose other members may provoke a crisis through their penchant to interfere. Husband and wife may show forbearance towards each other, but by the time their kinsmen have muddled the waters of controversy their marriage may be shattered. The interference may come from either side.

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Lineages

In Case IV it is the husband's older brother who goes so far as to summon the wife to court because he argues she is causing the waste of his brother's property when she publicizes his affairs. In another instance, it was the husband's mother's brother who wrecked his marriage in the process of standing on the husband's rights. This occurred in 1950 when a young wife attempted  146 suicide after being beaten by her husband who suspected her of adultery. Her father told the husband that he must find a goat for the purification rite which must be performed after such an attempt. At the meeting to discuss the matter, the husband's mother's brother argued that they would not give a goat since it was the wife who had attempted suicide

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and it was therefore her own relatives who must supply the goat. He told them, 'Perhaps you do not know the custom of the Tonga. If a person tries to commit suicide and fails, then his matrilineal group must find a goat to kill for him so that the clan joking-partners can come and joke with him and eat the meat.' ¹ Long ago I had a wife who tried to kill herself. I called her matrilineal group to see what their daughter had done. Then they found the goat. After that I told them, "Now you must take your daughter. I do not want to be married to her." Now in this case, it is your daughter who is involved in *malweza*, ² and it is not our affair to find the goat.' When they heard this, the wife's relatives said, 'We see you do not want our daughter, and that is why you refuse to find the goat. We will go to court because it was her husband who beat her and made her try to kill herself.' The husband's mother's brother retorted, 'All right. You can go to court, but you should think that it is your daughter's fault. She decided that she did not want to return to her husband and so she tried suicide. It is entirely her affair.' Meantime the young husband, who was thoroughly upset about the matter, kept protesting his willingness to find a goat since he wanted his wife to return to him. His mother's brother silenced him and continued to insist that no goat would be given. Later the husband mourned to other people that he had wanted his wife, but that his mother's brother had insisted on speaking for him and had ruined his marriage.

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¹ See Colson, 1953 *b*.

² For definition of term, see p. 126.

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